IELTS Momentum

Elite IELTS 7.0+ · Band 6.0–6.5 to 7.0+

Student's Book · Week 2: Politics and government

An IELTSflow Signature Course. All texts and tasks in this book are original IELTSflow material.

This week

Listening: opinions and attitudes in Section 3. **Speaking:** Part 2 stories that sound alive.

Reading: the writer's views (Yes / No / Not Given). **Writing:** Task 1 overviews that a band 7 examiner wants to read.

Grammar: advanced relative structures. **Sunday:** MOCK 2. Bring your Mock 1 writing feedback to Lesson 3.

Week 2 · Lesson 1 Listening + Speaking

Topic: The role of the state · **Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced:** Unit 8 · **Exam focus:** Listening Section 3 – multiple choice and matching; Speaking Part 2 – storytelling

1 Warm-up: four corners (10 min)

Your teacher reads a statement. Go to the corner that matches your view: **strongly agree · agree · disagree · strongly disagree**. Agree on your two best reasons as a corner, then one person reports.

1. Voting should be compulsory.
2. The government should decide how much sugar is allowed in food.
3. Public transport should be free for everyone.
4. Sixteen-year-olds should be allowed to vote.

2 Vocabulary: state control

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
legislation	a law or set of laws made by a parliament	New **legislation** bans smoking in all cafés.
implement	to put a plan, law or decision into action	The reform will be **implemented** in stages.
regulate	to control an activity with rules	The state **regulates** the price of bread.
subsidise / subsidy	to pay part of the cost of something / money paid in this way	Public transport is heavily **subsidised**.
welfare state	a system in which the government pays for health care, pensions and benefits	Sweden is known for its generous **welfare state**.
bureaucracy	a complicated system of official rules and procedures	Excessive **bureaucracy** slows down new businesses.
nationalise / privatise	to bring a company under state / private ownership	The railways were **privatised** in the 1990s.
intervene / intervention	to become involved in order to change a situation	The government **intervened** to stop prices rising.

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
compulsory	required by law or a rule	Voting is **compulsory** in Australia.
enforce	to make sure people obey a law	The new speed limits are strictly **enforced**.
nanny state	(disapproving) a government that controls people's lives too much	Critics called the sugar tax an example of the **nanny state**.
civil liberties	the basic rights of citizens, e.g. freedom of speech	Surveillance cameras raise concerns about **civil liberties**.
accountable	having to explain your actions and accept responsibility	Ministers must be **accountable** to parliament.
public spending	money spent by the government	**Public spending** on education rose by 10%.
impose	to force people to accept a rule, tax or punishment	The city **imposed** a fine for littering.

Group work

Word experts: Pair A teaches words 1–8, Pair B teaches words 9–15: definition, your own example, and one **collocation** (e.g. *introduce legislation, heavily subsidised, strictly enforce*).

Who said it? In threes, write one sentence that a **supporter** of the nanny state would say and one a **critic** would say, using at least four words from the list. Read them out; the class guesses which is which.

Practice. Complete the sentences with a word from the list in the correct form.

1 Wearing a seatbelt is ……. in most countries.

2 The new rules are pointless if the police do not ……. them.

3 Many people believe the state should not ……. in private family decisions.

4 Farmers receive ……. to keep food prices low.

5 Opening a café involves a great deal of …….: dozens of forms and permits.

6 Some argue that cameras in every street threaten our …….

7 The government ……. a tax on sugary drinks in 2019.

8 Politicians must be ……. for the way they spend public money.

3 Listening (20 min)

Listening slot: Cambridge IELTS 16, Test 1, Part 3 (choose two + matching)

Section 3 is about opinions, not facts. Two or three speakers agree, disagree, change their minds or correct each other. The answer is often what they **finally decide**.

Listen for attitude signals: *I'm not convinced that … · That's a fair point, but … · Actually, I've changed my mind · I suppose you're right · What worries me is …*

Choose two: the options you hear first are often **rejected**. Wait for the reason.

Group work

Before (3 min): in pairs, underline the key words in each option and write a **synonym** above each one (*expensive* ➜ *costly / not cheap*).

After (7 min): in threes, compare answers. For each question, one person must quote **what the speaker said** that proves the answer. Disagree? Listen to that part again.

Signal hunt: with the transcript, each team finds and underlines every phrase that shows agreement, disagreement or a change of mind. The team with the most correct phrases wins.

4 Speaking Part 2: tell a story, don't make a list

	Example
Band 6 talk	*I want to talk about my uncle. He is a leader in our town. He is very kind and helpful. He helped many people. He is also hard-working. So I admire him.*
Band 7+ talk	*The person I'd like to talk about is my uncle, who has been the head of our mahalla committee for about ten years. What I remember most clearly is the winter when the heating in our block broke down. While everyone else was complaining, he spent three days phoning officials until, eventually, engineers turned up …*

	Example
The story structure: S–P–T–R **S**et the scene – who, where, when (1–2 sentences). **P**roblem – what went wrong or what was difficult. **T**urning point – the moment something changed: *That was when …, Just as …, It was only when … that …* **R**eflection – what you learned / how you feel now: *Looking back, … · It made me realise that …* **Make it vivid:** precise verbs (*rushed, insisted, persuaded, refused*), not *went, said, did*; a short **direct quote**: *He just said, 'Leave it to me.'*	
Group work **Story chain (5 min):** teams of four tell one story together, one S–P–T–R stage each, about a time a neighbour or local official solved a problem. **Verb upgrade:** swap your notes with another team and replace three general verbs with precise ones. **4–3–2:** tell your card to partner 1 in 4 minutes, partner 2 in 3 minutes, partner 3 in 2 minutes. Each time, keep the same story but make it tighter.	
Describe a person in your community who has helped to solve a local problem. You should say: • who this person is • what the problem was • what they did to solve it and explain how you feel about what they did.	
Describe a rule or law that you think should be changed. You should say: • what the rule or law is • who it affects • why you think it should change and explain how you would change it.	

Week 2 · Lesson 2 Reading + Writing

Topic: Tackling issues · **Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced:** Unit 14 · **Exam focus:** Reading – Yes / No / Not Given; Writing Task 1 – overviews and data selection

1 Vocabulary: tackling issues (12 min)

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
tackle	to make a determined effort to deal with a problem	The plan aims to **tackle** youth unemployment.
address an issue	to start dealing with a problem	The report fails to **address the issue** of cost.
root cause	the basic, original cause of a problem	Poverty is often a **root cause** of crime.
alleviate	to make a problem or suffering less severe	Free school meals **alleviate** child hunger.
exacerbate	to make a bad situation worse	Cutting bus services would **exacerbate** traffic problems.
controversial	causing a lot of disagreement	The new tax proved highly **controversial**.
consensus	general agreement among a group	There is broad **consensus** that reform is needed.
deliberate / deliberation	to think about or discuss something carefully	The jury **deliberated** for two days.
representative (adj)	typical of a larger group	The sample was **representative** of the whole population.
mandate	the authority to act, given by voters	The new government has a strong **mandate** for change.
turnout	the percentage of people who vote	**Turnout** among young people was only 40%.
disillusioned	disappointed because something is not as good as you believed	Many voters are **disillusioned** with politics.
grassroots	involving ordinary people rather than leaders	The campaign began as a **grassroots** movement.

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
referendum	a vote by all citizens on a single question	The change was approved in a national **referendum**.
legitimacy	the quality of being fair and acceptable according to the law or to most people	Low turnout weakened the **legitimacy** of the result.

Group work

Collocation grid: in pairs, match each verb to as many nouns as possible: *tackle / address / alleviate / exacerbate + a problem, poverty, an issue, tension, the root cause, suffering*. Which combinations are **not** natural?

Problem doctor: each pair chooses a local problem (traffic in Kokand, youth unemployment, plastic waste …) and explains it to another pair in 60 seconds using five words from the list.

Practice. Choose the correct word.

1 The new policy aims to (alleviate / exacerbate) poverty in rural areas.

2 Experts agree that low wages are the (root cause / consensus) of the problem.

3 The proposal was so (controversial / representative) that protests broke out.

4 After the scandal, many voters became (disillusioned / accountable) with politics.

5 The decision was put to a national (mandate / referendum).

6 The movement started at a (grassroots / turnout) level and grew quickly.

2 Reading: Passage 3 level

Exam strategy: Yes / No / Not Given (the writer's views)

YES – the statement agrees with the **writer's** opinion. **NO** – it contradicts the writer's opinion. **NOT GIVEN** – the writer does not say what they think about this.

1 Find the **opinion signals** in the text: *in my view, I would argue, it seems to me, perhaps the most …, should, far too …*

2 Don't confuse **facts** or **other people's views** (*critics say, supporters reply*) with the **writer's** view.

3 Check **strength** words: *always, never, should, only, all*. × *always reach the right decision* vs ✓ *can open up debates*.

Group work

Team prediction (3 min): from the title and subtitle, decide: is the writer probably for, against or balanced? Write one sentence – check later.

Solo exam work (20 min): answer Questions 1–13 alone, in silence.

Opinion detectives: in threes, highlight every phrase where the **writer** gives an opinion (one colour) and where **other people** do (another colour). Then agree your answers – evidence only.

You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 1–13, which are based on the reading passage below.

Government by lottery?

Should ordinary people chosen at random help to make political decisions? The idea is ancient, but it is returning.

In most democracies, ordinary citizens influence political decisions mainly by voting every few years for representatives, who then make decisions on their behalf. Yet surveys in many countries suggest that trust in those representatives has fallen, and a growing number of governments have begun to experiment with an idea that is, in fact, far older than elections themselves: giving real political responsibility to a group of people chosen at random.

In Athens in the fifth and fourth centuries BC, many public officials were selected not by vote but by lot. Each year, the Council of 500, which prepared the business of the citizens' Assembly, was filled by drawing names, and the Athenians developed a stone allotment machine, known as a kleroterion, to select the large juries that decided court cases. To the Athenians, elections were in some ways less democratic than a lottery, since they tended to favour the wealthy, the well-known and the persuasive. It should be remembered, of course, that only adult male citizens could take part; women, slaves and foreign residents were excluded. Even so, the principle that any citizen is capable of sharing in government remains a powerful one, and modern democracies, in my view, have been far too quick to forget it.

The modern version of the Athenian system is usually called a citizens' assembly. Its members are selected by a process known as sortition, normally using stratified random sampling, so that the group reflects the wider population in terms of age, gender, region and level of education. Members are usually paid for their time. Over several weekends, they hear evidence from experts and from campaigners on different sides of an issue, discuss it in small groups led by trained facilitators, and finally vote on a set of recommendations. Some commentators describe the process as 'a jury for policy', and the comparison is a useful one: like jurors, members are not expected to be specialists, only to listen carefully and judge fairly.

The best-known success story comes from Ireland. Between 2012 and 2014, a Convention on the Constitution, made up of 66 randomly selected citizens and 33 politicians, recommended that same-sex marriage should be permitted, and in 2015 Ireland became the first country in the world to approve it by popular vote. In 2016, a Citizens' Assembly of 99 randomly chosen members, chaired by the Supreme Court judge Mary Laffoy, was asked to consider the Eighth Amendment to the Constitution, which had placed a near-total ban on abortion since 1983. After five weekends of deliberation, a clear majority recommended change, and in a referendum in 2018, 66.4% of voters chose to remove the amendment. What these examples show, I would argue, is not that citizens' assemblies always reach the 'right' conclusions, but that they can open up debates that politicians have long been reluctant to touch.

Not every assembly has been so influential. In 2004, the Canadian province of British Columbia asked 160 randomly selected citizens to examine its voting system. They recommended a new method known as the single transferable vote, and the proposal was put to a referendum in 2005. It won 57.7% of the vote, but the provincial government had set a threshold of 60%, so it was not adopted; when the question was asked again in 2009, support fell to around 39%. In France, the Citizens' Convention for Climate brought together 150 randomly chosen people in 2019 and 2020, and produced 149 proposals. President Emmanuel Macron had promised to pass them on 'without filter', but many were later weakened or dropped, and several members publicly expressed their disappointment. The lesson, it seems to me, is that an assembly is only as powerful as the commitment of the politicians who create it.

Critics raise several objections. The most common is that ordinary people lack the expertise to make decisions about complex questions such as taxation or climate policy. Supporters reply that members are given expert evidence, and that observers have often been surprised by how carefully participants deal with difficult material. A more serious objection concerns legitimacy: because members are not elected, the public cannot vote them out or hold them accountable in the usual way. There are also practical concerns about cost and time, since a single assembly may meet over several months. Perhaps the most worrying criticism, however, is that the organisers who choose which experts and campaigners are heard may, deliberately or not, shape the outcome. This seems to me the strongest argument against the idea, and it explains why the design of an assembly matters at least as much as the principle behind it.

Some places have gone further and made the process permanent. In 2019, the German-speaking Community of Belgium, a small region in the east of the country, created a standing Citizens' Council of 24 members chosen by lot. The council selects topics and organises temporary citizens' panels, whose recommendations the regional parliament is required to debate. It is still too

early to say whether such models will spread widely. Citizens' assemblies will not, and should not, replace elected parliaments; they are slow, they depend on the goodwill of governments, and they can only consider one issue at a time. But at a time when many voters feel that no one is listening to them, these assemblies may offer something that elections alone cannot: a chance for ordinary people not only to be heard, but to listen to each other.

Questions 1–9

Do the following statements agree with the views of the writer? Write **YES** if the statement agrees with the views of the writer, **NO** if the statement contradicts the views of the writer, **NOT GIVEN** if it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this.

1 Modern democracies have paid too little attention to the Athenian belief that any citizen can share in government. ____

2 The exclusion of women and slaves means that Athenian democracy has nothing to teach us today. ____

3 Comparing a citizens' assembly to a jury is helpful. ____

4 Citizens' assemblies can be relied on to reach the correct decision. ____

5 The Irish assemblies helped to raise issues that politicians had avoided. ____

6 The 60% threshold set in British Columbia was unfair. ____

7 The impact of an assembly depends largely on politicians' willingness to act on its proposals. ____

8 The choice of experts who speak to an assembly could influence its conclusions. ____

9 Citizens' assemblies should eventually take the place of elected parliaments. ____

Questions 10–13

Complete the sentences. Choose **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** from the passage for each answer.

10 In ancient Athens, a machine called a …… was used to choose members of juries.

11 The selection of assembly members by lot is known as ……

12 In 2015, Ireland approved …… by a popular vote.

13 The French climate convention produced …… proposals.

Group work

Discussion (5 min): Would a citizens' assembly work in Uzbekistan? What topic would you give it? Decide as a team and present in 30 seconds.

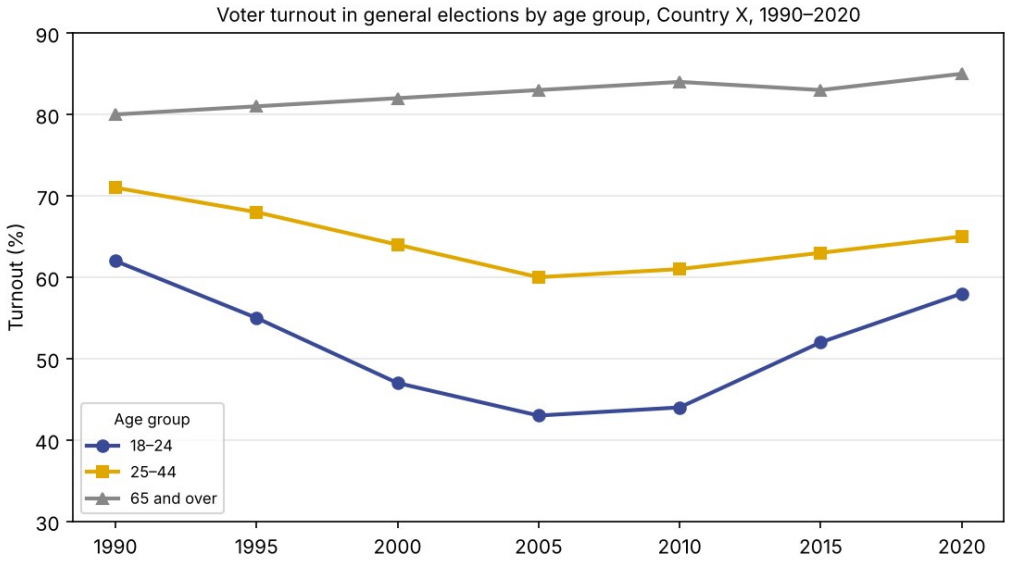
3 Writing Task 1: the overview

Why the overview decides your band

Task Achievement band 7 needs **'a clear overview of main trends, differences or stages'**. Without an overview, you cannot get more than **band 5** for this criterion, however good your details are.

Four questions for any overview: 1 What is the **biggest** / most important category? 2 What is the **general trend** (up / down / stable)? 3 Which change or difference is **most striking**? 4 Is there a **pattern** (a gap that widens, a reversal, groups that behave alike)?

No numbers in the overview. Begin with *Overall, …* and write **2 sentences**.



Group work

Overview race (6 min): in pairs, answer the four questions for the line graph. Then write a 2-sentence overview on a mini-whiteboard. Hold them up – the class votes for the most precise one.

Data selection: as a team, choose only the **6–8 figures** you will use. Which numbers would you **leave out**, and why?

Paragraph split: decide how to divide the details into two body paragraphs (by time? by group?). Defend your choice to another team.

Language for change	Band 7 examples
Precise verbs	edge up · climb steadily · plunge · dip · recover · level off · peak at · bottom out at
Noun phrases	a steady decline **in** turnout · a sharp recovery **to** 58% · a fall **of** almost a third

Comparison	considerably / slightly higher than · twice as … as · the gap between … widened to …
Relative / participle	…, **which** was still four points below its 1990 level · …, **reaching** a peak of 85%

Task. Write the full report (20 minutes, at least 150 words).

The graph shows voter turnout in general elections by age group in Country X between 1990 and 2020. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.

Week 2 · Lesson 3 Grammar + Writing clinic + Speaking clinic

Grammar: Advanced relative structures · **Vocabulary Files C2:** Unit 2, Politics and government · **Accuracy:** Common Mistakes at Proficiency, Units 3–4

1 Warm-up: politics collocations (8 min)

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
cast a vote	to vote	Over two million people **cast their votes**.
come to power	to start governing	The party **came to power** in 2016.
hold office	to have an official political position	She **held office** as mayor for eight years.
a landslide victory	a win by a very large majority	The party won **a landslide victory**.
a hung parliament	a parliament in which no party has a majority	The election produced **a hung parliament**.
swing voter	a voter who does not always support the same party	Both parties targeted **swing voters**.
pass a bill	to approve a proposed law	Parliament **passed the bill** by 210 votes to 95.
U-turn	a complete change of policy	The minister made a **U-turn** on fuel prices.
political apathy	a lack of interest in politics	**Political apathy** is common among students.
checks and balances	rules that stop one part of government having too much power	Courts provide **checks and balances** on the government.

Group work

Headline writers: in pairs, write three newspaper headlines about an imaginary election using collocations from the list (*Landslide victory for Green Party*). Another pair turns each headline into a full sentence.

2 Grammar: advanced relative structures

Group work

Discovery (5 min): find three relative clauses in the reading passage (paragraphs 2–4). For each, say: what does *which / who* refer to? Could you remove the commas?

Structure	Example
preposition + which / whom	the system **under which** they are chosen · the people **to whom** they report
whereby (= by which)	a process **whereby** members are chosen by lot
the extent to which / the degree to which	**The extent to which** assemblies influence policy is unclear.
quantifier + of whom / of which	150 citizens, **most of whom** had never been involved in politics
sentential which (refers to the whole clause)	Turnout fell to 43%, **which** alarmed politicians.
reduced relative (-ing / -ed)	citizens **chosen** at random · voters **living** in rural areas
noun + to-infinitive	the first country **to approve** it by popular vote

Rules and warnings

1 Formal writing puts the preposition **before** *which / whom*: the law **to which** I object (speaking: *the law I object to*).

2 After a preposition, use **which / whom** – never *that* or *who*: × *the party in that I believe*.

3 **Non-defining** clauses (extra information) need commas and cannot use *that*: Ireland, **which** held a referendum in 2018, …

4 Don't repeat the object: × the law which the government introduced **it**. (Uzbek speakers often add *it / him* here.)

5 *whose* for possession: a country **whose** voting age is 16.

Exercise 1. Join the sentences using the word in brackets.

1 Voters choose representatives. Representatives make decisions for them. (who)

_____

_____

2 Members are selected by lot. This is the process. (whereby)

_____

_____

3 100 people took part. Most of them had never voted. (most of whom)

_____

4 Turnout rose sharply in 2020. This surprised many experts. (which)

_____

5 It is not clear. To what extent do young people trust parliament? (the extent to which)

_____

6 This is the committee. The minister must report to it. (to which)

_____

Exercise 2. Find and correct the mistake.

1 The law which the government introduced it was unpopular.

2 This is the system in that citizens are chosen at random.

3 The minister, that resigned last week, has been replaced.

4 There were 99 members, most of them were women.

5 Voters lived in rural areas often have less access to information.

Group work

Relative clause auction: teams get 1,000 points. Bid on sentences your teacher reads – some are correct, some are wrong. Buy only the correct ones. The team with the most correct sentences wins.

Define it! One student defines a word from this week using a relative structure (It's a system **whereby** …); the team guesses the word.

3 Writing clinic: Task 1 + Mock 1 feedback

Peer review – Task 1 band 7 checklist

☐ The introduction paraphrases the question (not copied).

☐ There is a clear **2-sentence overview** with **no numbers**.

☐ Key figures are **selected**, not listed; every number has a **date and a group**.

☐ Comparisons are made (*whereas, compared with, the gap …*).

☐ At least one advanced relative or participle clause.

☐ No opinion and no explanation of **why** the figures changed.

Group work

Swap and score: swap reports with a partner. Tick the checklist, and give a Task Achievement band (6 or 7) with **one** reason.

Mock 1 error hunt: in threes, read each other's Mock 1 essays. Find the **most common error** in the group and write a mini-rule for it on the board.

Rewrite your overview and one body paragraph after the review.

4 Speaking clinic: Parts 2 and 3

Describe a time when you had to make a decision for a group.

You should say:
- what the decision was
- who was in the group
- how you made the decision

and explain whether it was a good decision.

Part 3: discussion questions
1 Should young people be more involved in politics? How?
2 Is it better for decisions to be made by experts or by ordinary people?
3 Why do some people lose interest in politics?
4 How might technology change the way people vote in the future?

Group work

Triads: candidate, examiner, observer. The candidate gives the Part 2 talk using S–P–T–R, then answers two Part 3 questions. The observer listens for **one** advanced relative structure and **one** precise verb. Swap roles.

5 Accuracy slot: Common Mistakes at Proficiency, Units 3–4

Group work

Be the teacher: each pair corrects two sentences and explains the mistake to the class in one sentence.

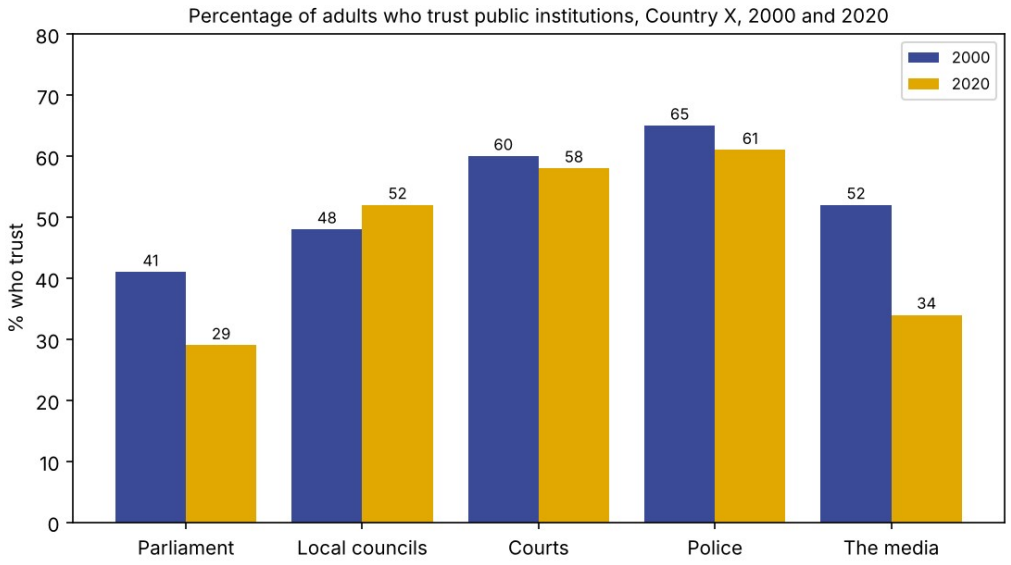
1 The government has made a lot of efforts to reduce poverty.
2 Young people are not interested about politics.
3 The minister refused answering the journalists' questions.
4 The new law will be come into force next year.
5 Many politicians lack of experience in business.
6 It's high time the government takes action on pollution.

Week 2 · Homework (3–4 hours a day)

Day	Tasks
Day 1 (after L1)	Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced Unit 8 · Record both Part 2 cards from Lesson 1 (S–P–T–R) · Cambridge IELTS 17 Listening Section 3 + signal-phrase log
Day 2	Cambridge IELTS 17: one Reading passage with YNNG (20 min) · Write the opinion signals you found · 10 sentences with this week's words
Day 3 (after L2)	Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced Unit 14 · **Writing: the bar chart below (20 min, 150+ words)**
Day 4	Grammar Exercise 3 · Record the Part 2 + 3 set below and send it to your teacher · Reading: one passage + paraphrase log
Day 5 (after L3)	Rewrite your line-graph report · Vocabulary Files C2 Unit 2 exercises · Common Mistakes at Proficiency Units 3–4
Day 6	Review all 40 words and collocations · Rest before **MOCK 2** on Sunday

Writing Task 1 (homework)

The chart shows the percentage of adults in Country X who said they trusted five public institutions in 2000 and 2020. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.



Grammar Exercise 3. Write six sentences about politics in your country, using: whereby · most of whom · the extent to which · sentential which · a reduced relative · preposition + which.

Speaking Part 2 + Part 3 (record and send)

Describe a leader you admire.

You should say:

- who this leader is
- what they lead
- what qualities they have

and explain why you admire them.

Then answer: (1) What qualities does a good political leader need? (2) Should there be an age limit for politicians? (3) Why do people sometimes stop trusting their leaders?